

Organization Reference – The Barbarian's Cup

DA reference: milestone descriptions with cross-link instructions. Read when a milestone square is reached on the Operations Board.

01 – The Broker – João Rosário (Starting Value: 6 → 8 squares open)

Professional antiquities trafficker, former seminary student. Terrified of the cup. Motivated by closing the auction and getting the cup out of his life. Has a complicated history with the Covenant – informant, target, and broker, sometimes simultaneously.

01M1 (Day 6): Rosário's nerve cracks. He contacts the Covenant through an old backchannel and offers information – selectively. He reveals the bidders' code names but not their real identities. He wants the Covenant to know he's cooperating, but he's still trying to maintain deniability with the bidders. → **I4 (Rosário's Covenant history) becomes available. I5 (bidders identified) becomes available. Advance 04 (the Monk) by 1 – Shi Yánxìn learns Rosário is wavering and intensifies his own search.**

01M2 (Day 3): Rosário tries to cancel the auction. The bidders refuse. The Al-Quds Front threatens his family. Rosário is now a hostage in his own operation – he cannot stop the auction even though he desperately wants to. His cooperation with the agents becomes more urgent and reckless. → **I6 (auction in jeopardy) becomes available. Advance 02 (Al-Quds Front) by 1 – the Front escalates from bidder to enforcer.**

02 – Al-Quds Liberation Front (Starting Value: 8 → 10 squares open)

Fictional extremist group. Cell leader Farouk Al-Masri (NPC2) is inexperienced and afraid. Second-in-command Nasim (NPC3) is the real danger – a nihilist obsessed with the cup. The Front's leadership considers this a low-priority acquisition; the cell was sent almost as an afterthought.

02M1 (Day 8): Private viewing. Farouk handles the cup (gloved) and is visibly shaken. Nasim is enraptured. The Front increases their bid to \$5M. Nasim begins carrying a photograph of the cup in his shirt pocket – over his heart. → **I9 (the Front's viewing) becomes available. NPC3's obsession begins. CT-1 evidence present at L3 (the dead orchid – Nasim accidentally touched the cup to a water droplet).**

02M2 (Day 5): Nasim takes operational control. Farouk is sidelined – he's still nominally the cell leader, but Nasim no longer listens to him. The Front begins planning not just acquisition but deployment – Nasim has identified a reservoir serving the Hong Kong New Territories. → **I12 (the Front's target) becomes available. I17 (Farouk's doubts) becomes available. Advance 05 (Macau Police) by 1 – police detect financial planning activity linked to the Front.**

02M3 (Day 2): The Front moves to Coloane. Nasim has stopped sleeping – 2 hours a night, maximum. He believes the cup speaks to him. (It doesn't. He's sleep-deprived and radicalized, but the cup IS humming, and Nasim CAN hear it – he's just wrong about what it means.) → **NPC3 is now hostile and unpredictable. I19 (Nasim's obsession) becomes available. Advance 03 (Daewon) by 1 – Daewon detects Front movement and escalates their own timeline.**

03 – Daewon Pharmaceutical (Starting Value: 8 → 10 squares open)

Seoul-based pharmaceutical company. CEO Park Min-ho (NPC4) is a wellness-guru true believer who thinks the cup is his destiny. R&D head Yoon Seo-yeon (NPC5) is a ruthless pragmatist who is starting to have ethical doubts. The company has not told its board what the cup actually does.

O3M1 (Day 7): Daewon corporate security team arrives in Macau. They set up a mobile lab in a Coloane warehouse – biosafety level 3, staffed by former ROK special forces. Park gives an interview to a Korean business magazine about "an imminent breakthrough in holistic medicine." → **I10 (Daewon's theory) becomes available. Advance 06 (Chinese State Security) by 1 – Chinese intelligence notices the unusual corporate activity in Macau.**

O3M2 (Day 4): Yoon's preliminary analysis of residue from the viewing room (she swabbed the table after the cup was removed) confirms: the poison kills everything. Including human cells. There is no therapeutic window. She tells Park. Park says "we can work with that." Yoon begins to have ethical doubts – she keeps copies of the data. → **I14 (Yoon's analysis) becomes available. I15 (Park's journal) becomes available. NPC5's disposition shifts – she may become a whistleblower if agents approach her correctly.**

O3M3 (Day 2): Daewon moves to the fort. They've brought a biosafety container and a \$7M cashier's check. Park plans to address the cup directly before taking possession – "it needs to know it's going to a good home." Yoon is in the hazmat van outside, ready to receive the cup – and increasingly unsure she wants to. → **NPC4 is present at L7. NPC5 is present at L7 (in the van). Advance 02 by 1 – the Front learns Daewon's bid amount and becomes desperate.**

04 – The Monk – Shi Yánxìn (Starting Value: 5 → 7 squares open)

Shi Yánxìn, 74, last guardian of the cup. Hid it from Red Guards in 1966 at age 14. Spent 8 years in a labor camp. Has been searching for the cup since his release in 1974. Walks with a stick. Feeds pigeons in Camões Garden. Dry sense of humor. Carries 60 years of guilt – the apology he plans to give the cup is 13 years long.

O4M1 (Day 6): The monk makes contact with the agents. He's been watching them since they arrived – from the park bench, from across the street, from the back of the tea house. He's been waiting for someone who might help. He reveals the cup's true history (Bodhidharma, Shaolin, the ritual) and what broke it (the Cultural Revolution, the interrupted ritual, the drift from "poison to delusion" to literal poison). → **I7 (the true history) becomes available. I8 (what broke the cup) becomes available. CT-2 (appetite) source unlocked – the monk explains what the cup is drawn to.**

O4M2 (Day 3): The monk reveals the quiescence condition – a surface never touched by violence. He has one: a stone from Bodhidharma's cave at Shaolin, sewn into the lining of his robe. He will give it to the agents if they promise to let him see the cup one last time before it's contained. He wants to apologize to it. → **I18 (the quiescence stone) becomes available. CT-3 (quiescence) source unlocked. If agents refuse the monk's request, he still helps – but he withholds the stone.**

05 – Macau Judiciary Police (DORMANT – Starting Value: 5 → 7 squares open)

Dormant until triggered by: (a) O2M2 (Front planning activity detected), (b) gunfire or violence at any Macau location, or (c) agents bringing Inspector Matias Guterres (NPC7) into the loop. Led by Inspector Guterres – methodical, honest, under-resourced.

O5M1 (Day 5): Triggered. Inspector Guterres opens an investigation into "suspicious financial activity" linked to Rosário's antique shop. Police presence increases at L1 (bank), L2 (antique shop), and L3 (tea house). Agents must use Sneak or Manipulate for covert access to those locations. Guterres is methodical – he won't jump to conclusions, but he's already noticing things that don't add up. → **I13 (police investigation opens) becomes available. NPC7 becomes active.**

O5M2 (Day 2): Guterres connects Rosário to the Front – the money trail leads from the antique shop to a Coloane fishing cottage. Counter-terrorism protocols activate. Macau security forces are now looking for the same people the agents are tracking. Guterres may raid the auction if he learns the location. → **I20 (police close in) becomes available. 05 becomes a complication at L7 – police raid possible. NPC7 may approach agents directly.**

06 – Chinese State Security (DORMANT – Starting Value: 7 → 9 squares open)

Dormant until triggered by: (a) 03M1 (Daewon corporate activity detected), (b) agents accessing the Hong Kong dealer's records, or (c) the auction location becoming known to Chinese intelligence. Led by Agent Chen Wei (NPC8) – professional, silent, operating at the edge of her mandate.

06M1 (Day 4): Triggered. Agent Chen of the Ministry of State Security identifies the cup as stolen cultural property – the file crossed her desk from a Hong Kong field office. A surveillance team is deployed to Macau. They are not hostile to the Covenant but will intervene if the cup is about to leave Chinese territory. Chen is competent and under-informed – she knows the cup is valuable, but not what it does. → **I16 (State Security interest) becomes available. NPC8 becomes active. Agents may notice surveillance (Investigate Diff 2).**

06M2 (Day 2): The MSS team moves to Coloane. Chen has connected the dots: the cup, the auction, the foreign bidders. She has orders to secure the cup for the state – "by any means necessary." She is not the enemy, but she will not negotiate. If agents attempt to smuggle the cup out of Chinese territory, she intervenes with deadly force. Her team of four is not messing around. → **I21 (MSS intervention) becomes available. 06 is a wildcard at L7. NPC8 is present at the fort.**

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